revetments *above* (Figures 5.3–5.7) – rather than replacing or atop – its Ghaznavid-period marble dadoes, creating a discernible contrast between what was already there and what was added in the course of Mu'izz al-Din's renovations. At Lashkari Bazar, the mosque of the South Palace's forecourt quite possibly received a new *mihrab* (Figure 5.18), in this case covering its Ghaznavid-era predecessor, but the mosque itself was not entirely built anew. Additionally, this palace's southern exterior façade (Figures 5.15 and 5.16) and enormous central courtyard (Figures 5.14, 5.19) also acquired new decorations and revetments, and the intimate oratory abutting Audience Hall I (Figures 5.20–5.22) displayed Shansabani renewal in its decoration, perhaps especially in its epigraphic program (cf. above and below). It was only at Bust that we detected new construction datable to the late twelfth-century conquest of the region by Mu'izz al-Din (Figures 5.8–5.11), but this also occurred amidst what appeared to be pre-existing built remains that continued in use (e.g., Figures 5.12 and 5.13). Thus, Ghazna, Bust, and Lashkari Bazar all entered Shansabani possession largely through appropriation, rather than erasure and new construction.

We might term this specific mode of building empire *re-inscription* – a process that we will encounter in the Ghazna Shansabanis' forays ever farther eastward (see Chapter 6). Re-inscription encompassed the reuse and at times repurposing of societal assets such as the built environment, usually through new endowments (Ar.-Pers. *waqf*) toward architectural and infrastructural maintenance made by the newcomers in perpetuity. Another fundamental component of re-inscription would have been the imperial prerogative of minting coinage in the name of the victorious ruler. While continuity with the standards and iconographic fields of existing coinage preserved stability, the stamping of the incoming ruler's titles and name declared the ascendancy of a new imperial authority. 'Ala' al-Din Husain *Jahan-suz* had done just this upon his second conquest of Ghazna, continuing the typology of the late Ghaznavid ruler Khusrau Shah's (r. AH 552–555?/1157–1160? CE) coins but substituting his own titles and name. His nephew Mu'izz al-Din followed suit: he maintained the standards and fields of late Ghaznavid coinage, replacing the titles and names with his own – perhaps even airing the family's "dirty laundry" by revealing to the world his resentment against submission to his older brother, Sultan Ghiyath al-Din of Firuzkuh.[50]

Collectively, the architectural interventions at Ghazna and other imperial Ghaznavid sites indicate not only that enough had survived in recuperable condition despite 'Ala' al-Din Husain's depredations a quarter-century before, as well as the decade-long nomadic encampments of the Oghüz; they underscore a subtle process occurring in plain sight: re-inscription, rather than erasure and re-building, appears to have been Mu'izz al-Din's preferred method of claiming his conquests and building empire. To be sure, reoccupation of perfectly usable spaces was economical